

Savvy Everyday Politics

“E

very breath you take
Every move you make
Every bond you break
Every step you take
I'll be watching you"

Sting (1983)

by **Guillermo Wechsler**



As Sting's lyrics alert us, everyday politics can become suffocating. It can happen in love or in Twitter, just as portrayed by Henry Melville's *Moby Dick* narration of clashes, mutinies, and distress on board the captain Ahab's whaling ship *The Pequod*, at San Francisco Bay.

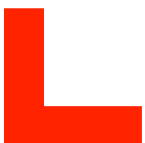
Everyday politics accompanies human imagination in each world. To Harry Seldon Foundation group of psycho-historians at Terminus, at the end of Asimov's declining Galactic Empire, or to Plato's immaterial soul, where appetites, passion and reasons negotiate their harmonious constitutional order in an allegorical cave.

Politics is an ever-present aspect of our lives, but it is often met with defiance. Over the past two centuries, as modernity took hold and democratic institutions were established in the Western world, we came to accept the idea that politics and business should remain separate spheres with clear boundaries. Thus, those of us in leadership roles within businesses tend to avoid investing time and effort in political matters.

Uncontainable, however, everyday politics transcends all borders, confronting us with challenges that have historical significance. Our deeply ingrained Western belief in segregating politics from other aspects of life proves to be ineffective. Treating politics as a second-class activity within the highly professionalized business world hinders us rather than helps. Worst of all, this approach causes us to overlook valuable and relevant insights.

Indeed, history has shown us that savvy everyday politics can shine with sophistication and hold significant value. By recognizing the importance of politics in our daily lives and engaging with it thoughtfully, we can gain valuable insights and make better-informed decisions that can positively impact our society and organizations.

This text presents a collection of situations in which sensitivity to hierarchies, order, trust, norms, cultural styles, concerns, or values can make a difference in overcoming a political impasse. The stories we present are aimed to recognize patterns, evoke valuable memories, and explore novel pathways for collaborative change. We think that the power lies in the images and ideas these accounts trigger in your thoughts, not just the words we use to describe them. Embracing your sparks of inspiration can unlock insights and fresh viewpoints on the regular flow of political events.





Family Politics in Imperial China

In the East, particularly in China, the demarcation between politics and private life has not been as pronounced as in the modern West. According to historian Michael Szonyi from Harvard University, the concept of 'everyday politics' has played a pivotal role in explaining China's remarkable and rapid transition from poverty to a position of dominance on the global stage.

Szonyi points out that detailed records found in intergenerational family journals have enabled historians to trace the trajectory of everyday politics throughout late imperial China.

The institutional arrangement called junhu regulated the military obligations of families within the empire. At least one healthy adult man per family should be committed to serve the army for each generation. The army was a risky business, and the prospect of serving in the imperial army for life created challenges for families.

The 14th century Zheng family from the southeast coast had the obligation to decide which of the eldest brothers should serve the military duties of the Ming dynasty junhu. The two brothers and their families engaged in lengthy conversations of mutual evaluations, unsolved debts, multigenerational aspirations, and negotiations of all sorts. Eventually, a decision involving intergenerational redistributions and compensations was achieved. The younger brother accepted to serve junhu obligations after the will of his father was adjusted in his favor.

This decision had enormous consequences as it affected the lineage of the younger brother in perpetuity. Years later was the turn of the three sons of the younger brother to engage in junhu negotiations. This time, the negotiation revolved around something different than material resources and possessions. The value available for negotiation was the descendant's priority to participate and conduct family ancestral sacrifices in the future. The families settled based on symbolic capital redistribution and social recognition.

The imperial regime granted every family the freedom

to define its own style of negotiations. They had some explicit rules and some value based tacit norms. Most of them were recorded in legally binding contracts and in the family's handsomely bound printed volumes of extended genealogical journals describing ancestral tomb locations, biographies of prominent members, and rules for managing shared property. Some families opted for committing the life of one of their descendants to serve the junhu, while others took multi-year turns or negotiated a contract with a mercenary willing to supplant the family in its obligations.

There was broad range of distributed institutional arrangement in the everyday politics of Chinese families. The Wang family genealogy described that a wealthy member of the lineage donated a piece of property for the collective good. The land was rented out, and the rental income used to compensate the monk and his descendants for supplanting the Wang family in its junhu duties. The Guo family of Fuzhou, a few hundred miles to the north of Quanzhou, became registered as a military household when one of their members, a fellow named Guo Jianlang, was implicated in a murder. When Guo Jianlang died, the obligation was transmitted to his surviving relatives.

The term 'everyday politics' describes the political strategies, conflicts, and negotiations of this massive middle social ground. Ben Kerkvliet, political scientist, characterized everyday politics as running businesses while 'embracing, complying with, adjusting, and contesting norms and rules regarding authority over, production of, or allocation of resources,' doing so in quiet, mundane, and subtle expressions and acts.'

'Everyday politics.' 'Our social nature 'thrown' us to engage in organized social activities that precede us. In an abstract level, those activities can be understood as historically organized games that have specific purposes, rules, participants, scoring criteria and strategies. Everyday politics is a game about the preservation and the evolution of a game. In other words, everyday politics is a game about a game. Delivering a new version of a particular software is a technological activity. Declaring the architecture of roles in the software development process is a political activity. Any human activity requires both conversations to act in a social game and conversations to define and evolve the game in which we act. As in Escher's 1948 hand lithography, our shared worlds are circular. This second type of conversations we call everyday politics encompasses declaring standards, defining conflict resolution mechanisms, designing protocols of engagement, repairing the background of trust, adjusting the constitutional rules of the game, or negotiating institutional arrangements to address emerging concerns in a way that expands the common benefit.

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Everyday politics a 'quiet, mundane, and subtle' efforts, by ordinary people, to gain political advantage in a system where they seemed to have little agency, had significant consequences in the Chinese social fabric.

At its essence, politics is the discipline that sees all activities in their capacity to shape, maintain, and expand a world in which individuals, organizations, and institutional role identities thrive toward a meaningful shared future, knitting the everyday social order.

We absorb most of our everyday politics sensitivities and skills by engaging in social activity. Myriad of behaviors became habitual by doing, emulating, trying, and adjusting a practice. The Zheng, Guo, Wang Chinese families are a sophisticated educational system in which they learn innumerable micro-practices such as meeting family members, listening actively, gathering multiple generations, understanding individual and collective aspirations, recording historical events and inspiring biographies, identifying and negotiating conflicts, recognizing situational hierarchies, appreciating value nuances, celebrating long-term agreements, and complying with commands, such as the imperial mandate of junhu obligations.

Modern Western families engage in this type of activities too. Particularly the segment of families with dynastic ambitions, with a well established practice to address multi-family, multi-generational matters that requires political savvy to negotiate and settle long term concerns.

When we look around with the lens of ordinary politics, we see that there is a vast social landscape of genuine political practices grounded in values and principles that largely transcend what is commonly identify with 'ideological' politics.

Even in the most rigid environment, there is room for wise ordinary politics. We want to uncover the virtues of that ancient pervasive and rich politics in the primordial realm of everyday activities, because it is a critical skill to navigate change and recompose a virtuous order.

Myth on Office Politics and Politics Micro-practices

The article “You can’t sit out office Politics (2021)” the HBR author Niven Postma formulated four claims about everyday office politics.

First, we have negative prejudices about politics. Politics sound dirty, unethical and at odds with a meritocratic, professional organization. We do not see that the opposite could be true too.

Second, we think that office politics can be avoided, and we pay a high price by denying the domain instead of learning to play in it. The reality is that careers demand a legitimate political effort that includes building relationships, identifying strategic concerns of a variety of stakeholders or making yourself invited to new social circles.

Third, politics can be horrible and wasteful; but we tend to dismiss that it can also be productive. The reality is that often political savvy is the difference between nightmare and success.

Fourth, we think that digitalization and remote work makes office politics less relevant. The reality is that remote and digital work environment only change the ways of doing politics; but it does not suppress it.

Regarding office politics Niven Postma exercises the old wisdom of warning us of not throwing the baby with the water. Instead of herd prejudices she suggests discernment and the cultivation of what we call everyday political micro-practices.

Politics is a vast and nested territory. Then to navigate politics and cultivate political savvy, we propose to start with simple practices. Practices that we can enrich iteratively. We are not going to solve all the issues at once; but we are going to have some successes, some interesting failures, humor, and many new questions to explore.

Micro-practice. We can make a social or business game more interesting and valuable by learning new skills inside the game and/or by learning how to redefine the game.

Games can be very structured as chess or basketball, or they can be more flexible as a self-regulated open-source projects. Games can have a large set of explicit rules, such as the life insurance service, or a large set of tacit rules, as in friendship.

Whatever the case, games are created and evolved by making declarations. Declarations are a powerful linguistic skill we exercise when we appoint a new role in a teamwork; when we announce a new business partnership; when we brand a new product.

When we are granted with the authority to make a declaration by a team, a market, or an institution, we can declare new entities in a game, new rules to play the game or new objectives to win the game. We propose that the essence of savvy everyday politics is about learning micro-practices to identify, play, assess and reconfigure business games.

Any business practice can be reconstructed as a game constituted by three sets of declarations:

- 1. The point of the game or how to win the game*
- 2. The entities of the game or the players and artifacts*
- 3. The agency in the game or the actions that are allowed and the actions that are forbidden.*

As always is the case with games, the difference of a joyful experience or a nightmare, it will be found in the architecture of rules that defines the game and the chances to win it; in how we cope with a pre-existing nested hierarchy of games, or in the skills of the players to perform the required actions of the game.

Savvy everyday politics is about to recognize the issue and evolve the situation.



Trust. Trust is not a mere perception; it transcends feelings. Trust forms the very foundation upon which our words derive significance. It is a multi-dimensional evaluation encompassing involvement, responsibility, and sincerity. Involvement hinges on the ability to listen the perspectives of others and proactively foresee potential risks, opportunities, and avenues for change that hold relevance not only for them but for us as well. In essence, involvement equates to genuine care. Responsibility denotes the proficiency to uphold commitments consistently and with unwavering accountability, around the clock. No room for excuses or non-sense. Sincerity embodies the art of making public commitments that seamlessly align with private intentions and obligations to deliver. The goal of such assessments is to restore trust. This is achieved through meticulous examination of evidence, adherence to validation criteria, adjustment of behaviors, and the elimination of inefficiencies. The most straightforward approach to cultivating trust is to commence with the sharing and addressing of trust assessments. Couple this with transparent promises and a consistent track record of timely fulfillment.

We will illustrate what we mean by political micro-practices with a work experience. A few years ago, we spent several weeks in East China preparing an explosive growth strategy for an online recruitment business. The commercial team was concerned with developing *guanxi* in key accounts. What is *guanxi*? We asked. For the Chinese executives, it was a way to create relationships, address customer executives' concerns, explore venues of collaboration, and increase mutual

loyalty. For the Western executives, it was a problematic practice, hard to manage, and often seen as plain corruption. There was sharp disagreement on both teams. The Chinese executives felt they were stigmatized and forced into an irrational approach. The Western executives felt they must defend Western professional ethics. There was a background of unresolved issues, and the conflict was eroding the chances of success.

Conflict management and conflict resolution are relevant micro-practices in everyday politics. We played by the book. In general, conflict management has three challenges. To accept that there are different concerns and perspectives among the stakeholders; to accept the consequences of the misalignments; and to articulate an alternative game that can improve the current situation.

We consulted and interviewed team members, recorded their stories, identified their concerns, highlighted their assessments in those stories, and discussed the validity and evidence behind those assessments. We collected the interviews, conducted a couple of rounds of consultation, and sketched a diagnosis on perspectives, misalignments, and potential value at stake. Then, we proposed a discussion with the team and scheduled a meeting to come to a resolution.

The first move of the meeting was to name the White Elephants in the room: distrust between members of the executive team. It is not possible to start a dialogue without re-establishing a sound background of trust. We provided them with a framework to evaluate and repair trust issues, working with specific cases. We showed the team that it was possible to bring a White Elephant to the meeting, to have a good conversation about the issue and define actions to address it. The trust issues revealed that there were some additional 'corpses in the closet'. We created a task force to solve that legacy issue. At that point, the team was in a new spirit, and conversations were open and direct.

Then, we were in good shape to address the guanxi issue.

The end solution was to create a taxonomy of guanxi, with its specific business rationale and value metrics; to distinguish types of acceptable and not acceptable guanxi; and to coach the team to identify misalignment in cultural standards and a protocol to address those situations. Months of friction got evaporated in a couple of days.

Admittedly, some everyday political issues can be more demanding. Certain tasks may immerse us in highly dysfunctional work environments. Long episodes of fire-drills in large projects, failed M&A processes, functional misalignment, and broken business operating models are all situations in which toxic

circumstances and degraded politics may emerge.

Still, amidst this milieu, there will be always a variety of mind sets. We will surely find some individuals diligently endeavoring to fulfill their personal, contractual, and/or institutional responsibilities; and another group that tends to passivity and avoidance. In any given present situation, you can identify people who better represent the obsolete past that you want to overcome; people who represent the future you want in the culture of the organization; and people in the middle looking at Hamlet's skull. Everyday politics is about structuring new conversations to enroll people living in the obsolete past, to engage with the emergent future.

In such circumstances, being politically savvy might involve steering clear of psychological gossip and cynical dispositions, instead inviting others to adopt a more positive mindset to assess the situation and identify potential avenues. Regardless of how dire the circumstances may appear, opportunities to generate value persist.

Some white elephants may need to be named. Some old friction may need a more careful conflict management set up. Some 'corpses in the closet may need to be addressed'. Invariably, the re-appropriation of the past opens the space for new futures. Declarations such as 'there is no way out of this' represents a particular state of mind. An interpretation of events shaped by an individual, a peer group, or an expert team inviting others to buy into the narrative of resignation. As Aristotle alerts, resignation is a damaging and contagious state of mind. To flag it is the first step to dissolve it.



Mapping the Territory: Maps are tentative sketches of understanding, providing context and navigational horizon. There's no need to hesitate when employing visual depictions of your customers and stakeholders. A lucid record that distinguishes between perceptions, feelings, and observable occurrences, interview notes, individual concerns and aspirations, informal roles, hierarchical positions within the organizational chart, process roles, and reporting dependencies matrix. Uphold a rigorous approach to data, addressing the who, what, when, why, and how. The point of the game is to make visible a network of recurrent interplays between roles, and target opportunities for delivering experiences of empowerment in the emerging world.



In a different realm in 2018, at the Belfer Center, Kissinger and Graham Allison were commenting on great power politics. Henry Kissinger shared few interesting insights of micro-practices based in his experience of negotiating with Chinese officials. He notices three remarkable differences of approach in the game of creating share worlds.

He observed that in the Western mindset, problem-solving is completing and discarding a to-do list. Arriving to the solution vanishes the obligation, the stakeholder's concern and the stakeholder itself.

Consequently, when a problem is solved, the attention swiftly shifts to the next task to solve in the to-do list. The original issues fall out of the radar as soon as they are 'solved'. Conversely, the Chinese problem-solving approach starts with the solution. When they believe an agreement has been reached on a particular solution to an issue, they view it as the commencement of a cascade of new challenges. Subsequently, they convene individuals, analysts, and task groups in an extensive consultation process to ascertain the potential effects of the proposed solution on various entities and stakeholders. Thus, when the work of our diplomatic mission concluded -remarked Kissinger- for the Chinese delegation work was just starting.

It took a while for Kissinger to appreciate the singularity of these Chinese game rules to build collaboration. Initially, he reacted with distrust, thinking that the Chinese official were postponing the solution or obstructing the solution to the initial issues. Later, he appreciated the value of active consultation. The point of the game of active consultation of stakeholders was to listen the consequences of the new solution and to transform objections in opportunities for additional value. Then, the challenge was for Kissinger to adjust his own team to a new problem-solving game. Kissinger did the complete transition from reactive frustration with the Chinese style, to admiration and implementation of new micro-practices. A transition that is not possible without trust and respect.

Consultation. Consultation involves extending an invitation and enrolling the stakeholders impacted by a specific initiative to engage in a collective conversation to shape the ultimate outcome. Consultation does not equal democratic representation; but collaborative negotiations between agents with differential power. This collective is composed of individual roles, institutions, or any territorial entity willing to have a voice in the conversation. The goal is gathering new concerns, experiences, apprehensions, and use collective creativity to extend the initial solution. The consultation process facilitates the identification, articulation, and orchestration of controversies in a collective polyphasic social mind. Frequently, this process has the potential to thoroughly reshape the original initiative, emerging as a wellspring of simplification, improvements, or innovation. Thereby bolstering the assurance of success. Conversely, a feeble consultation process results in aimless activity and derails projects from their intended course.

Then came Kissinger again, introducing a new comparison, this time rooted in the art of Chinese patience and perseverance. He claimed that the Chinese don't haphazardly oppose the current; instead, they gracefully navigate its course. A sense of purpose guides them, attuned to the ceaseless rhythm underpinning events and the calculated maneuvers threaded into their aims. Consequently, their paramount focus doesn't merely fixate on a confined endgame. No, it's more profound – it's about understanding their role in this intricate dance of partnership.

This understanding surpasses superficial appearances or hollow rituals. It delves into something deeper – acknowledgment, not just for spectacle, but as a gateway to journey together with their counterparts. They unabashedly demand recognition of their idiosyncrasies, their political hierarchy, the unique tapestry of their culture, and the weight of their history. Why? So, they can position themselves aptly, fortified to tackle the twists and turns that inevitably materialize on the road to their intent.

In syntheses, for the Chinese the cultivation of respect is primordial to navigate a relationship with strategic ambitions.

Respect. Respect is a dimension of social capital of strategic relevance. Being respectful is treating the other in such way that their dignity is preserve in their own terms, regardless of the parts abysmal differences. Taste and cultural styles are tyrannic. When we arrive to a new office, or company, or market there are things we hate and things we love. If we are going to work together, we may need to negotiate standards of privacy, distance, dressing code, tone, or declarative power. Respect requires a sustained effort to make explicit what was tacit in our feelings in such way that negotiation and 'cultural contracts' can be celebrated and honored. Success in keeping respectful environments dissipate prejudgments, develop mutual appreciation for this or that singularity, and often let rise genuine admiration for mutual differences.

The last distinctive aspect that called Kissinger attention was the Chinese emphasis on attentive listening. Kissinger once engaged in a private conversation with the Chinese ambassador in Washington, during which he noticed that while he brought one professional note-taker, his Chinese counterpart arrived with three

note-takers. Intrigued, Kissinger inquired about this practice, and the Chinese ambassador gladly offered an enlightening response. He explained that the notes of professional takers often exhibit significant differences and nuanced variations. Each divergence represents an opportunity to pause, formulate questions, explore new possibilities, or anticipate potential misunderstandings arising from cultural, administrative, or worldview differences. The Chinese ambassador allowed his note-takers ample time to discuss thoroughly, delineating areas of apparent clarity, confusion, or controversy. This method ensured a comprehensive report, with clear interpretative controversial perspectives, that he could then contrast with his own sensitivities.



Redundant note-takers are a simple micro-practice organized around a distinctive game: catching differences between observations, assessments and feelings of different note-takers as a vehicle to expand stakeholders' listening. Differences should not be 'averaged', 'resolved' or 'discarded', but upheld as a

tension to be explored. Central is the recognition of the inadequacy of pursuing a course of action that dismisses the noted divergences. Instead, the strategy calls for an approach that bestows significance upon the inherent tensions therein, thereby fostering an environment conducive to their comprehensive exploration. In this context, these tensions are not relegated to the status of inconveniences, but rather serve as illuminating beacons, guiding the discourse towards novel dimensions of insight.

In Chat-GPT's words, the operational paradigm embedded in this simple micro-practice can be characterized as a choreography of contrasts, an orchestrated symphony of incongruities. The imperative here is to heed the clarion call of these differences, prompting a proactive engagement aimed at unpacking their latent complexities. By embracing this analytical ethos, an enriched comprehension of the subject matter emerges, inviting a more profound, multilayered engagement with the intricacies of the landscape at hand.



Listening into the Dialogue. Musicians have a refined sense of hearing, adept at reproducing sounds, notes, nuances, rhythms, and the phonetics of words. When asked, "Can you repeat what I just said?"; it is a testament to the power of hearing and the ability to reproduce sounds.

In contrast, listening is an act of empathy and capacity to identify emotions, anomalies, emergence, risks, or possibilities. It's about immersing oneself in another's world to unlock a new opportunity. Excellent listeners may not always reproduce sounds perfectly, but they have a knack for detecting nuances others miss. They envision futures previously unimagined. True listening involves being fully present in the speaker's world, which demands a deep dive into the listener's own historical time.

Usually, merchants engaged locals, experts in their cultures, to bridge gaps in diplomacy and politics. Similarly, we enlist subject matter experts on our teams to perceive what we might overlook. The interplay between language, practice, and understanding is profound.

The idea of universally understood messages is a myth. This deeply rooted belief has curtailed our ability to truly listen. A message takes shape in the interpretation of the listener, triggering unique thoughts in their mind. It varies from one individual to another and depends on the situation.

At the heart of listening is an involuntary, singular response. This is why, in communication and relationships, it's often more insightful to probe reactions than to merely speak and echo. Active listeners inquire about the audience's feelings, thoughts, and internal narratives. Candid feedback is invaluable. Welcome transparency and concentrate on capturing what's unique, meaningful, and actionable. Treasure every insight shared with you.

Our capacity to listen is enhanced by the linguistic nuances we grasp or formulate. We don't just listen with our ears; we listen through our linguistic understanding and our emotional reverberation. If one cannot discern something, it remains invisible to them. Classics texts achieve their status because they delineate concepts foundational to our civilization, ranging from physics to love, from economics to politics, and from fantasy to faith.

Enhance your listening skills by collaboratively crafting an interview guide. Delve into the roles your interviewees currently occupy, and explore the intricate web of interactions that sustain their current roles-identities and self-identities. Which relationships thrive, and which face challenges? Which are transparent, and which remain hidden? What's the current state of mutual goals and commitments? To truly listen, one must trace the intricate web of human and non-human relationships.



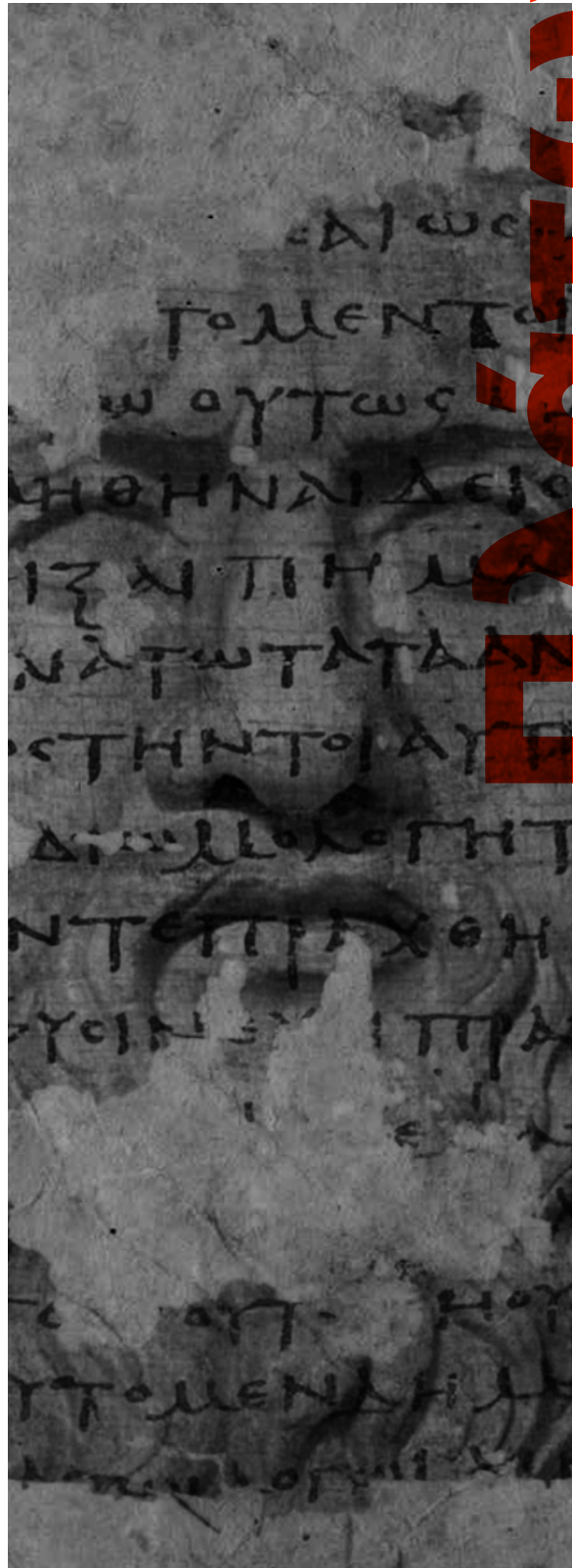
Synthesizing, Kissinger's reflections impart three fundamental lessons applicable to business everyday politics. He underscores the imperative of embracing a paradigm of solutions that extends beyond mere contractual deliverables. Rather, it encourages iterative processes of consultation, recognizing the intrinsic value of continuous engagement and open deliberation to refine and enhance outcomes. He emphasizes the significance of mutual respect even in scenarios where parity of power is not present. A rather Confucian twist to our Western understanding of respect. We all may be equals when buying a train ticket, but we are not equals when performing specific social, institutional, or business roles. This recognition highlights that the pursuit of shared objectives demands an equitable regard for all stakeholders to negotiate and settle their disparities in influence or standing. Lastly, he invites to re-examine the art of listening. Wherein attention is directed not solely towards that which appears self-evident or within one's accustomed understanding.

There is not much value in listening what we already know how to listen. Instead, the transformative potential lies in utilizing disparities to provoke an unsettling pause, a critical explorative consultation, and the expansion of one's own comprehension, emotional sensitivities, and one's listening capacity.

Western Dialogue and Collaborative Thinking

Yale University professor Steven Smith introduces Plato's *The Republic* to his students of political philosophy as 'the book that started it all.' The ultimate source on political savvy. Alfred North Whitehead, the mathematician and philosopher from Cambridge University, once remarked that the Western philosophical tradition could be best described as a sequence of elaborations on Plato's ideas, notably his work "The Republic."

Plato shaped the parameters of Western political thought, establishing a foundational framework in everybody's mind. His ideas have endured through time, serving as an enduring touchstone for both



expanding upon his concepts and engaging in critical discourse that challenges his viewpoints.

Engaging with and molding the realm of ordinary politics can be re-discovered and enhanced through an infusion of ancient philosophers. As stated initially in this document, one of the perils associated with intertwining politics into daily pursuits is the inclination to label it as a demeaning endeavor. We acknowledge the validity of such concerns. Nevertheless, it's imperative to recognize that politics is inherently intertwined with our fundamental human essence and possesses the potential to be executed with remarkable savvy.

The Republic initiates with a narration of Socrates and Glaucon descending to the Piraeus, about two thousand four hundred years ago. Professor Smith brings to the attention of Yale post-graduate students the nuanced structure of Plato's dialogue. The term 'descending,' as employed in this opening passage, might evoke a sense of sanctity akin to residing in a state of enlightenment within the realm of daily existence. It signifies a grounding in practicality, a shift from abstract concepts to tangible circumstances, and an intricate interplay with diversity, discord, hierarchies, disorder, transgression, and concession. In essence, politics, much like all other facets of existence, remains intricately woven within the confines of human situations.

The Piraeus harbor was buoyant. Socrates says, 'I went down yesterday to the Piraeus with Glaucon, the son of Ariston, that I might offer up my prayers to the goddess Bendis because I wanted to see in what manner they would celebrate the festival (the Bendideia) which was a new thing. I was delighted with the procession of the inhabitants, but that of the Thracians (Artemis) was equally, if not more, beautiful.' The book that 'started it all' in Western politics takes the form of dialogues and everyday affairs relating people and goddesses. The foundations of politics must be seen in the immediate surroundings.

The elite of Athens was gathering in a private celebration of Bendis at Cephalus' place. An invitation was handled by a servant to Socrates. Neither Socrates nor Glaucon wanted to attend Cephalus' invitation to his palace offerings. Nevertheless, Cephalus' heir, Polemarchus, insisted and demanded attendance. Glaucon suggested Socrates to concede, as he

understood the cost of being insensitive to ranks, hierarchies and social order. There is no freedom without constraints.

Minutes later, Cephalus, the embodiment of tradition, received Socrates with open arms, smiles, and sweet complaints for their prolonged absence from his palace. Socrates answered Cephalus, emphasizing the pleasure of having the opportunity to have a dialogue with an old man. Age comes with new freedom, Socrates asserted. 'The old man is relieved from the enslaving craving that desires impose on the young man. For certainly old age has a great sense of calm and freedom; when the passions relax their hold, then, as Sophocles says, we are freed from the grasp not of one mad master only, but of many.'

Socrates asked Cephalus about what will bring serenity to the completion of his life, what he may need to prepare to die with a sense of accomplishment and peace. What I need is to come to terms with my past, Cephalus responded, to settle debts I may have acquired by my past deeds, to do justice. Justice in the soul, justice in the city.

Plato invested considerable effort in establishing the necessary contextual backdrop before embarking on a dialogue. The city of Athens, the circumstances surrounding the event, the prevailing ambiance, the invitations extended, the assembly of participants, the sequence of proceedings, the hierarchical structure, and the very stage upon which this interaction unfolded – all these components were meticulously laid out. The initial discourse between Cephalus and Socrates could have easily maintained a surface-level, casual conversational tone, devoid of depth or relevance. However, Socrates chose to extend an elevated tribute to the older man who stood on the threshold of mortality.



Justice in the soul, justice in the city. In accordance with his customary practice, Socrates deliberately refrained from employing certain conceptual distinctions, such as 'justice,' within the discourse without taking deliberate pauses. He eschewed rushing through these concepts and instead engaged with the dialogue's participants in a process of deconstructing their meanings. He abstained from prematurely arriving at a fixed interpretation, seeking instead a mutually negotiated understanding that would sufficiently illuminate the possibilities encapsulated within Cephalus' profound moment.

In Plato's Socrates view, dialogues necessitate meticulous groundwork to uphold a fruitful collective intellectual exploration. A word may become an abyss or a bridge.



Dialogues. In the dialogue the conversation shapes the participants, and the participants shape the conversation. There is an interplay of reciprocal emotions, understandings, and binding actions. Emotions orient a conversation in advance. Frustration and anger set the course for conflict. Genuine enthusiasm discloses possibilities. Conviction overcomes mountains. Understanding set the plot in advance insinuating risks and possibilities, sketching characters' intentions, the environmental forces to be pondered, the discourses offering paths of intelligibility. Binding actions, mutual agreements, declarations, or mutual commitments shape the future of the unfolding intent. The dialogue connect us with the plurality of ourselves, the others in the city, on earth, below the sky. An adequate dialogue's declarative architecture creates a safe dwelling space to uncover, refine and explore differences in experiences, perceptions, words, conceptual distinctions and possible new futures. The foundational virtue of everyday politics.



Plato's magnum opus, "The Republic," consists of ten books that traverse a diverse range of topics. These dialogues delve into the intricacies of human nature, the concept of justice, the boundaries of censorship, the creation of divine entities, the intricacies of language, the delineation of labor divisions, the artistry of manual craftsmanship, the dynamics of gender politics, the realm of education, the significance of formative years, the concept of recompense, the responsibilities of warfare, the virtues inherent in sovereign rule, and the various configurations of

governmental structures. Collectively, they paint a comprehensive portrait of the societal framework and some pathways to the inner world of the individual.

The societal framework of the city must not only be established but also safeguarded, expanded, and shielded against both internal erosion and criminality, as well as external onslaughts and catastrophes. Plato deliberately steered clear of solitary introspection, recognizing it as an insufficient driving force for genuine thought. Instead, he opted for dialogue – engaging in conversations among the diverse array of citizens in Athens – as the avenue through which to contemplate the intricacies of justice and order, in the pursuit of the collective well-being. Plato firmly believed that optimal thinking unfurled within the context of authentic dialogue. Within this carefully crafted space, the tone of discussion played a pivotal role, allowing ideas to flourish and perspectives to be respectfully debated.

Thinking happens in genuine consultation with the city stakeholders. There was courage to manifest a believe that does not fit with the norm, there was temperance to explore its consequences and accommodate diverse concerns, there was wisdom to learn from experience without suffocate creativity.

Regardless of the specific participants in the dialogue, Plato already had a framework and a set of assumptions about the nature of the individuals participating in the dialogue. Most of this provisional understanding is provided by the Cave allegory, an open metaphor to grasp the finitude of human truth, advising us against excessive certainty. Plato envisions individuals as beings possessing both body and soul. A finite material body subjected to degradation. An immaterial soul composed by appetites (epithumeticon), spiritedness (thumoeides), and rationality (logistikon) – three elements vying to establish the soul's inner hierarchy and order. Often lacking concordance.

According to Plato's perspective, regardless of the inherent nature of individuals, the political structure within the soul should not be approached independently from the political framework governing the city. In other words, the dialogues suggest treating individuals' harmony (inner world) and social harmony (external world) as part of a integrated phenomenon. Plato posits that a just and well-ordered city should

foster a harmonious balance within the souls of its inhabitants. He believes that politics should promote inner tranquility in individuals. Thus, he draws a parallel between societal governance and the manner in which individuals manage their emotional and mental well-being.

Plato also emphasizes that each genuine conversation conducive to thinking must stay vigilant of the language in which it is sustained. Plato's dialogues exhibited several micro-practices to keep language sharp and powerful. They often reviewed the meaning of a word in terms of what it distinguished for each of the different stakeholders, trying to hold what was shared and what was distinctive. The word justice showed to treasure many valuable meanings in multiple contexts. It was related to taking care of debts; with being trustworthy in fulfilling promises; or with displaying loyalty in decisive moments. Those meanings of justice were uncovered in dialogues. This visibility facilitated the process of refinement, enabling the collective to exercise prudence in subsequent conversations by addressing disparities and preventing misguided decision-making.

There was time to pause, review, ask questions, share experiences, help others to articulate the valuable singularities of their stories. The speakers are meticulous about reviewing their appraisals of language used to divide the good from the bad, the just from the unjust, the virtuous from the decadent. What makes a particular appraisal pertinent? What other appraisals may be needed to illuminate the phenomenon? What criteria are we using to validate those appraisals?

Languages in Dialogue: The essence of language is to distinguish something, in terms of something else. In other words, how to use an entity's change of state in one domain of action, to represent an event in another domain of action. Sounds, math symbols, words, music, code, paintings, or ideograms are languages we have used through countless generations to feel, observe, assess, and act in our shared worlds. Language reconfigures time, possibilities, and mutual obligations in a relationship, recoupling the future and the past in the present.

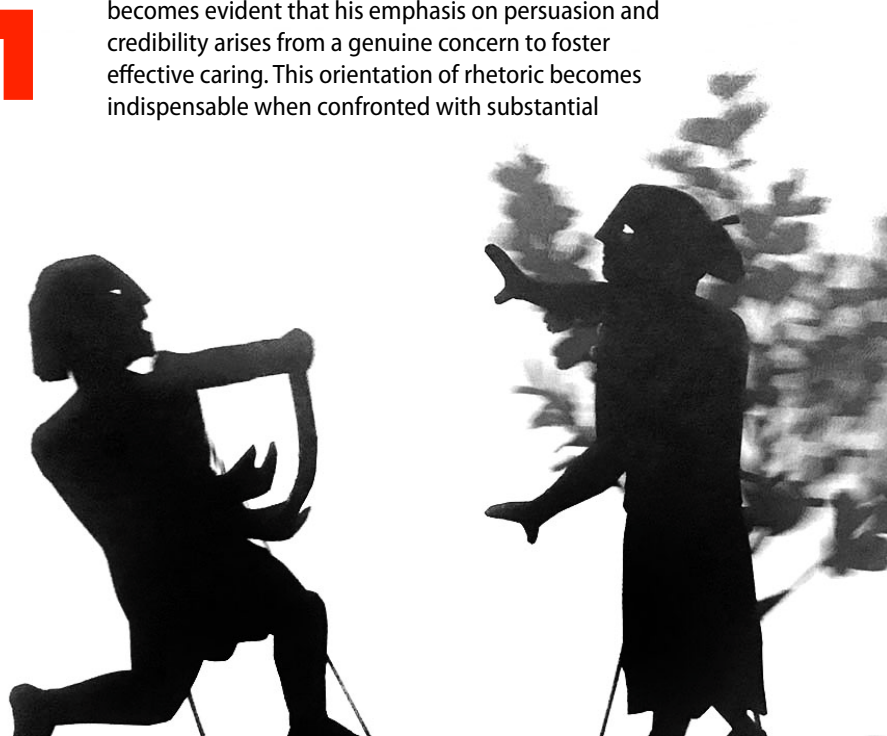
All that was relevant for the Athenians caring for their fellow citizens and their loved city is relevant today in our everyday activities. The scope may vary, the particularities of the situation may be different, but the concern, the passion, the questions and many of the games and micro-practices for shaping a vibrant shared world are still valid for any strategic or innovative initiative. Building the room for change, shaping the institutional arrangement that allows collaboration, evolving the culture by implementing new games and practices, or preserving the historical values.

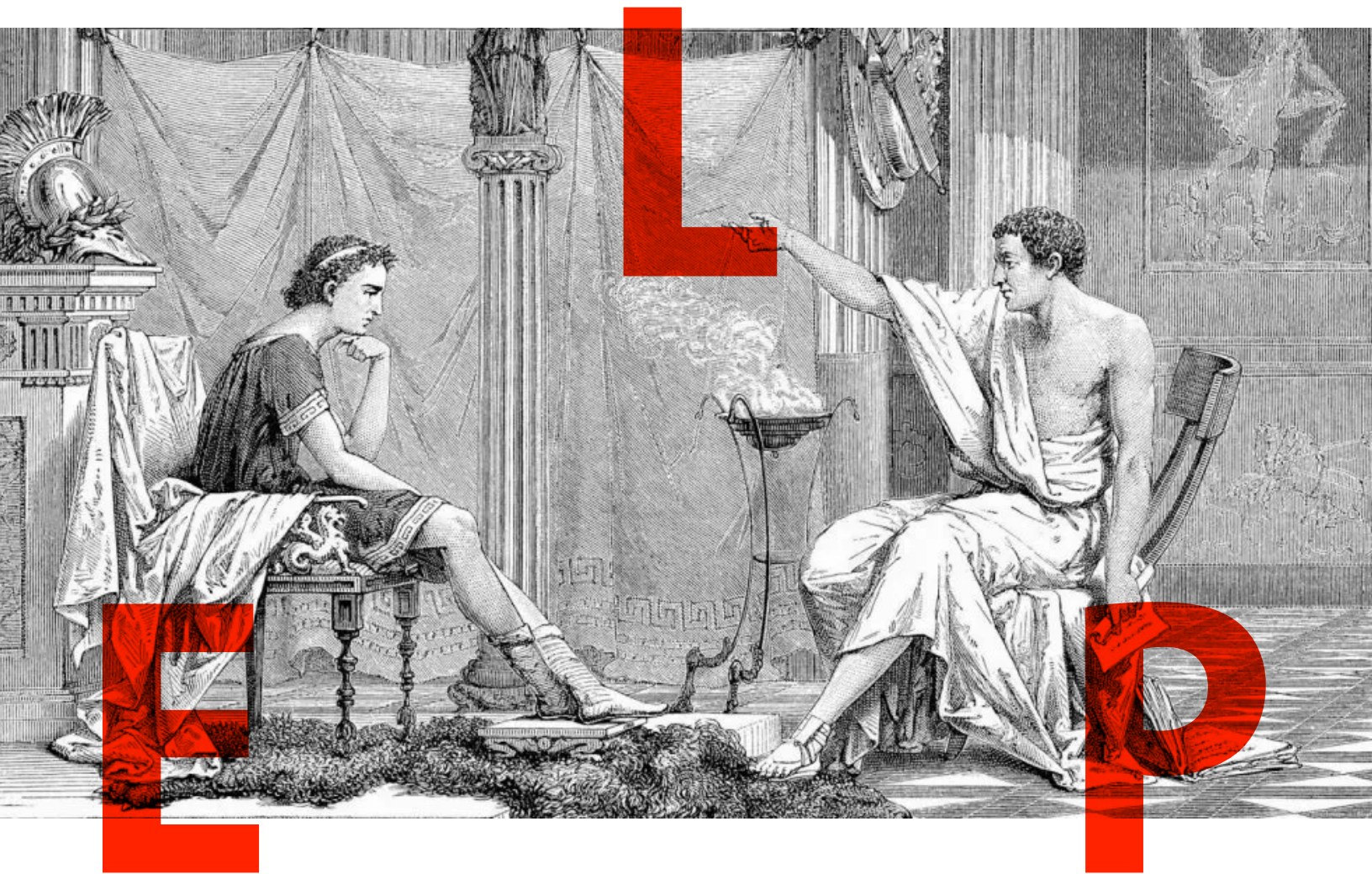
Aristotle, working from a different perspective than his mentor Plato, made a classic contribution to two aspects of savvy political agency, the cultivation of credibility and persuasion. His contribution is developed in his treatise *On Rhetoric*.

Rhetoric is frequently seen as 'the skill of being believable' even if the intention's truth is questionable. Hence, rhetoric becomes a tool for the clever puppeteer, the perceptive manipulator, akin to the Homeric character of Odysseus in the *Iliad*. Presenting rhetoric as the art of the astute puppeteer is undoubtedly an asset in the context of war; but not when the challenge is developing long-lasting relationships. Odysseus showed his manipulative and astute deceiving skills in the Trojan War, or against the Cyclops, but not in his relationship with his son Telemachus or his wife Penelope.

We will not explore rhetoric as the art of disguise.

Our focus orbits around exploring rhetoric as an attempt of instituting genuine persuasion and credibility. Through our analysis of Aristotle's *Rhetoric*, it becomes evident that his emphasis on persuasion and credibility arises from a genuine concern to foster effective caring. This orientation of rhetoric becomes indispensable when confronted with substantial





business dilemmas lacking unequivocal solutions. In such cases, relying solely on cleverness or manipulation may prove disastrous. An alternative approach that addresses before everything else the cultivation of relationship, is imperative.

Aristotle suggest that the cultivation of persuasion and credibility is unequivocally a social enterprise that involves ethics, affections, and reason.

Ethos, the ethical appeal that involves character , trustworthiness, practical wisdom, and the proven efficacy to care of others in a way that can be valued by them. And conversely, the discipline to avoid what damages ethos, such as insincerity, lack of accountability, inconsistency, shallow care, or pretending expertise.

The second dimension that Aristotle distinguishes is Pathos, the affects, the emotional, the mood.

The capacity to set a tone that allows being receptive, able to empathize with an audience, and showing genuine compassion. His suggestion is to favor a prudent expression of sentiments and avoid hiding or get distress about a difficulty. Find the right balance, the right attitude. To be companionate does not means to be forgiving carelessly. Cultivate the right mood and recognize enabling and blocking emotions. Pathos, he alerts us, gets damaged by hiding emotions, by excessive pity, by emotional manipulation, by failing to recognize emotions, by allowing negative moods such as resignation, resentment, or cynicism.

In the same vein than Aristotle, the advocate of the market par excellence, Adam Smith, explored the interplay of sentiments and value. His first book, "The Theory of Moral Sentiments" (1759), he expands on the relevance of empathy . Smith claimed that empathy is the foundation of moral sentiments that keeps open the path of collaboration.

The third avenue of persuasion is Logos, encompassing logical reasoning and language – akin to the iceberg's visible tip. It involves adeptly weaving deductive and inductive reasoning into a cohesive narrative that elucidates a situation. This encompasses presenting empirical evidence to substantiate the veracity of a claim and collaboratively setting a benchmark for shared assessments. It also means using a consistent line of past observations to describe a phenomenon and make it visible for diverse observers, allowing others to assess it and interpret it. In essence, it's the ability to produce a 'universal' equivalent observer, to unveil opportunities, and propel action. In Aristotle's view, Logos is undermined by using logical fallacies, misapplication of evidence, or a lack of coherence.

Aristotle's portrayal of the three pillars of credibility – trust, emotions, and reasoning – resonates deeply with an undeniable reality. Who among us wouldn't identify traces of these elements in memories of conversations with grandparents or insightful mentors? Most of us. That is what makes Aristotle's Rhetoric a classic.

By this juncture in the text, it's likely that you've encountered instances of both puzzlement and clarification. You might have seen reflections of yourself in scenarios akin to those depicted in the text. Certain themes, examples, and anecdotes may have struck a chord with you, unveiling fresh avenues for action. The key takeaways we wish for you to acknowledge are six:



- 1-** In the realm of everyday political savvy there is a broad variety of skills to develop to design missing games or fixing toxic games.
- 2-** There are not perfect solutions; but solutions that can deliver significant value. There is always room for a new step.
- 3-** Politics is not a second order discipline, but a discipline that requires cultivation, historical perspective, and practice. It is not a surprise to be surrounded by bad everyday politics.
- 4-** There are not obvious definite references to guide decision making.
- 5-** Conversation, dialogue, and honing powerful linguistic distinctions are pivotal micro-practices.
- 6-** Ancient philosophers can be critiqued in various regards; nevertheless, they unveil the common sense inherent within each of us, enabling us to recognize it. It's this underlying presence that qualifies them as classics of our civilization, the voices that frequently steer our decision-making.



Let's transition now to our concluding two sections.

In the next section our intent is to show that local everyday politics can play a role in the unfolding of historical events. Though, political savvy requires receptivity to a broad array of vector of force and unpredictable agencies.

In the last section we will introduce a framework to think the business case for improved politics in multiple contexts.

Historical Contingency and Everyday Politics

Politics is at its best when it fosters entirely new domains influenced by subtle, peripheral forces. This convergence happens when a particular area is primed for the disruptive birth of a novel realm. Whether it's the combustible dark bitumen, the spark from fabric interacting with amber and its gentle magnetic pull, or the lively particles viewed under a lens.

The demographic curve of the eighteenth century reveals a steep population increase. From that point, the global population surged. Numerous historical theories attempt to explain this, along with one illustrative anecdote.

In the Vienna Public Hospital, a low-level M.D. from Hungary named Ignaz Semmelweis discovered from the hospital data that in one section of the hospital, there was a women post-delivery mortality rate about 4%, and in another section, the mortality rate was about 10%. They were dying from puerperal fever. Dr. Semmelweis was shocked. He worked frantically, reviewing all the procedures, demographics of patients, clinical records, equipment, and hygienic protocols. He discovered nothing but an apparently innocuous asymmetry. The high mortality rate section was run by the most notorious medicine faculty professors who often lectured to the students doing autopsies at the morgue and later attended deliveries without a well-defined hygienic protocol. He tested an antiseptic chlorinated lime solution protocol before attending deliveries. The mortality dropped dramatically. As a result, Semmelweis got entangled in acrimonious arguments with the faculty establishment. Small corpuscles causing diseases to large mammals were not an established fact at that time. His data was questioned, and his hypothesis too. He was terminated and returned to Hungary. Semmelweis' hygienic protocol was abandoned. Women, mothers, continued dying for decades. A tragedy. Too many hard-working bright minds delivered blindness. Semmelweis seems to have been a salient clinician, with little understanding of power, and little political savvy. Microscopic observations, bacteria cultures, and lab protocols were not yet in his world. He was betting for a change, in a complex order, with few allies.



Individual and Collective Power. Power is neither an hereditary gene, nor a fix trait. Power is an assessment that someone make when an entity has a differential capacity to produce a result above all the rest. Power is an assessment about a differential capacity of action in a particular realm. Each individual embodies a form of contingent power in a situation. That distinct capacity for action is a power directed towards something specific; it is not a generic force. It could be the power to decode a genetic pool, the power to print transistors on a silicon wafer, or the power to facilitate global transactions. We can have personal power based in skills and sensitivities; institutional power based in the hierarchy and attributions of a role; or social power based in collective institutional arrangements. Abuse of power is an assessment made when someone use power in one domain, to get results in another domain, transgressing norm, values, or established regulations.

Few years later, the once ridiculed hypothesis of invisible corpuscles causing diseases to robust and large mammals enlisted a new ally. A young chemist at the École Normale Supérieure du Paris. A lab workaholic called Louis Pasteur. In comparison with Semmelweis, his technical credentials to influence hospital protocols were smaller. He was not even a physician. But he demonstrated to be a very wise everyday politician equipped with three historically emergent practices: microscopic observation, laboratories, and the chemical periodic table. He targeted collectives in distress. First, the producers of vinegar, during his research of fermentation, that enabled the vinegar producer to avoid sour taste and spoilage (1850-1860). With his new reputation, he was able to engage with the silk producers (1865) and discover the source of the pebrine disease affecting the silkworm, reviving the French silk industry. By 1865 he had disciples, followers in several fields, and his work on microorganisms and single points of contagium resurrected Semmelweis' work on puerperal fever. Pasteur continued bringing his lab to livestock farmers, developing vaccines and pasteurization methods that later became incorporated into hospital and human healthcare in general.

Probably Pasteur never studied Aristotle, but his scientific rhetoric was impeccable. Pasteur brought perplexity to a collective subsumed in distress and resignation; then identified and engaged with a variety of stakeholders to grasp a phenomenon; then meticulously brought lab and a language to make the invisible visible; and ultimately, he installed a new future and expanded his power to continue in a new cycle.

At the beginning of his career, Pasteur tirelessly looked at drops of vinegar under a microscope, distinguishing chemical structures in tiny crystals. An absurd occupation for all but a handful of colleges, which assisted an unprecedented population explosion.

Epilogue and Preamble

At the most abstract level, politics is just conversations to create conversations. A Lego-like structure of binding agreements that makes conversations that were impossible, possible. A bridge to engage with people

back and forth, for the sake of shaping and resolving concerns.

The conversational Lego of a new game may include declaring new roles; adjusting old roles; declaring action rules and a protocol of engagement; certifying instruments; agreeing on data sources and metrics; declaring protocols for producing agendas; practices for assessing and re-establishing trust, and so on and so forth.

Frequently, it entails seeking advice or counsel from seasoned participants, yet at its core, it is a straightforward practice necessitating repetition, trial, and error, and embracing the widening realm of uncertainty that accompanies the process of learning.

The point of the game in politics is simple. To establish a world order in which the stakeholders can thrive—whatever the world is. It can be a disruptive project, a traditional functional organization, or an early startup. The conversation will revolve around possibilities and impossibilities; risk, uncertainties, and certainties; personal interests; overall concerns, or protocols for dealing with conflicts, controversies, or restitution of trust.

In the business world, investments in political savvy are measured in terms of ROI or contribution to the business bottom line. For instance, the decision to invest in lobbying is measured in terms of the ROI of a new industry regulation established worldwide. The decision to invest in a micro-practice to bridge some gaps of trust or to improve conflict management capabilities in a plant, will be measured in accordance with a value model to repair some structural trust issues. If everyday politics has a low return, there will be something to review in the approach, in the implementation cost, in the value model, or in something else that needs to be adjusted.

In the world of the scientist and mathematician, everyday politics may be measured in different terms. For instance, its return can be measured in terms of access to university research departments, publications, labs, and grants for the sake of a Nobel Prize or a Field Medal type of contribution.

In the world of the national politician, probably politics is about gathering power, votes, and/or institutional appointments to key offices, for the sake of furthering

their power to expand national worlds in the global community.

And to return to the beginning of our conversation, in the world of newlywed, probably politics involves crafting a marital contract, cultivating norms and games that will allow them to thrive joyfully in the nested projects of the individuals, the couple, family and/or dynasty.

The Ethereum blockchain, conceived by Vitalik Buterin in conjunction with a team of associates, is adept at facilitating the execution of smart contracts and Decentralized Autonomous Organizations (DAOs). This is based on the guiding notion that the code itself serves as the contract. A DAO outlines parameters for collaboration, value creation, and value distribution within a decentralized business organization. Additionally, it delineates the conditions under which the established protocols can be modified and the governance rules for such modifications. While the progression of this technology has faced obstacles, the trajectory of digitally mediated political interactions is inexorable.

Subsequent to blockchain innovations, Artificial Intelligence (AI) emerges as the forthcoming paradigm of digitally mediated political dynamics. In this arena, the socio-cultural context for interpersonal connections is shaped by algorithms integrated into social-network platforms, among other digital infrastructures. Anticipations suggest that soon, a comprehensive regulatory framework will be instituted to initiate a long term debate to ensure transparency, accountability, and governance over AI algorithms that intercede in and shape our daily political interactions.

Digital innovations promise to usher in an unprecedented milieu that fosters and empowers collaborative institutional configurations and novel entities. Yet, the quintessential challenge of preserving a harmonious collective realm or a dynamic social fabric will persist unchanged. Politics will remain a nested game with multiple textures and levels of formalization. However, everything starts by a 'we-the-people...' creating the space for a new breath, a new move, a new bond.



Savvy Everyday Politics